

Which assembler?

If you take a walk down Lamington Road in Mumbai or Nehru Place in Delhi, you'll come across a myriad of assemblers—those who are informative and help you with your decision, to those who are nonchalant and indifferent. Assemblers are quite a misinterpreted lot—most of them are perceived as wolves, waiting to swindle you out of your last paisa. However, in most cases, nothing could be further from the truth.



Vivek Louis
OWNER OF AN
ASSEMBLED COMPUTER

“Assemblers want to sell you the fastest moving hardware they have in stock—it is wise to check the price, suitability and the warranties of the hardware offered by a variety of assemblers before going in for a system”

Many buyers have come across assemblers who have been helpful and patient, answering each query.

The trick to finding the right assembler is to not rush through your decision—buying a PC is often a one-time exercise. Take your time making your decision and review a few assemblers. You don't have to go with the system suggested by the first assembler. Go with the one who gives you the best deal, not only with respect to the system, but also in terms of after-sales support (see box: 'Choosing the Right Assembler').

Most assemblers interact directly with the grey market and their *modus operandi* is markedly different from the way MNC brands do business. Profit margins are different for assemblers since they deal in bulk quantities, while access to hardware and a whole range of components enable them to bring the latest hardware into the market faster than most MNC brands. Also, being smaller players, assemblers are capable of offering much more personalised support to their customers than large companies.

The buyer's guide

To get the best out of the assembler, you must be clear about your hardware requirements. Though a little ambiguity is expected if you are a first time buyer, a customer who insists on the buzzwords

of technology without knowing how it will help him can be quite exasperating. “Most people ask for a computer for a given application like surfing. They only know key words like Pentium 4, 3D accelerated graphics, etc and convincing them to buy suitable system configurations and capabilities is very difficult,” says Deepak Jotwani, proprietor of Future Shock, a Mumbai-based computer dealership. It's always a learning experience to know which component is compatible with

applications, then you would need to buy the fastest processor, with the maximum amount of RAM and hard disk you can afford. The scenario would be quite different if your priorities were reverse. Then you would do fine with a gigahertz-class processor, 128 MB of RAM with a good integrated graphics chipset such as an 845G-based Pentium 4 motherboard or an nForce-based board with a Duron processor.

Though most assemblers are helpful, it isn't a good idea to only depend on the assembler's suggestions regarding the hardware configuration that would be most suited to your needs. Assemblers tend to suggest only the hardware that they stock and there might be other hardware options that could get your job done at a lower price. With some background research on the best hardware suited to your needs, you can insist on your configuration. If the assembler doesn't have some of the hardware, you can always ask him to source it for you.

Very often, people tend to finalise the price of the system without taking into account the after-sales support and cost of the software. Inquire about the warranty period and the type of warranty (carry-in or on-site), so that you know how reliable your assembler is.

When it comes to software, you'll have to be a little wary. Unfortunately, most assemblers install the software without any regard for licensing issues. Make it a point to choose an assembler who provides you with legal OEM software—doing so makes it easier to obtain after-sales support on the software and upgrades. And it's the legal thing to do!

What do...		
...they say	...they mean	...you need to do
"It has a high-powered graphics card"	A TNT2 or integrated graphics solution that will just barely let you play the latest games	Find out the exact name of the graphics card and see if it suits your applications
"It's the lowest priced system among other vendors"	Sub-standard or very low powered components	Make sure that he isn't selling you secondhand or repaired system components
"Free printer/scanner/mouse bundled"	End-of-life peripherals that are on their way out of the market	Find out if these peripherals meet your need and have after-sales support that you would require later on
"Software installation extra"	Possibly pirated or outdated software with little hope of after-sales support	Go with vendors who offer lower-priced OEM versions of the software and whose cost is integrated into your system price